

The risk of monetising public education

Commercialisation of these institutions **undermines** their core mission which is to provide **inclusive, affordable** high-quality education to all

The Vice-Chancellor of JNU, Prof. C Santhishree D Pandit recently **remarked** that the country's top university is facing a **financial crunch** with little regular income generated from its resources. The VC has decided to **repurpose** the university's properties with private participation. This **culture** of looking at public academic institutions as a source of revenue **has** been **rhyming** among our policymakers during the past several years.

One reason is the huge prime land area holding maintained by the public sector institutions and another is the change in the shift in **societal perception**. Today's society **evaluates** everything based on money. The primary **objective** of public sector academic institutions **is** to offer an inclusive and excellent education to all sections of the population. **Central** to these institutions is the concept of education as a public good—a valuable asset that has advantages for society as a whole, rather than **solely** for individuals. Education, in this view, is not simply a product that can be purchased and sold, but rather a **profound** process that **moulds** individuals into knowledgeable, **reflective** members of society who are capable of making meaningful contributions to the collective welfare.

Their value should be **assessed** based on the number of **enlightened** minds generated by these institutions. As we can see it's these enlightened minds who are driving the wheel of the government machinery, and the nation's progress. Public sector academic institutions have been under growing pressure in recent **decades** to implement business-oriented strategies, which include prioritising income creation. The **transition** has been **prompted** by several circumstances, such as decreases in government financing, increasing operational expenses, and the expanding impact of market **ideology** in public policy. Consequently, **numerous** public universities and colleges have **resorted to** alternate sources of income, such as raising tuition fees, extending online programs, providing executive education courses, renting out spaces and forming **alliances** with private industry.

Private parties, if allowed to rent out spaces, **should** work closely with the academic and research community of the university. It should also help in **imparting** knowledge and transformation to students. In many NITs, the guest house rate has been increased **tenfold**, as **mandated** by the policymakers.

Unfortunately, **people** who visit these institutions including academicians and parents of students **have** to pay more than what is the market rate in that area. Although these initiatives can offer significant financial support, they also **pose** a **potential** threat of **altering** the **core** purpose of public

sector institutions. It can be **detrimental** to maintaining high academic standards and **fostering** a wide range of **intellectual perspectives**.

Additionally, it can generate pressures to give higher priority to programs and research areas that provide greater profits, **perhaps overlooking** subjects that are less financially rewarding but equally crucial for societal progress. It is **vital** to provide students with a well-rounded education that encourages **critical thinking** and **broad-based** knowledge.

Public sector academic institutions hold a **distinct** and crucial role in maintaining the **social fabric** of the nation. Their objective is not to earn financial gain but rather to generate enlightened minds capable of critical thinking, and contribute to the development of the nation.

The great minds working in every field, including the **bureaucrats** and political leaders **are groomed** by these public sector institutions. For this to continue, we should not put a price tag on every facility a public sector university offers to the student or society **at large**. [\[Practice Exercise\]](#)

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

Vocabulary

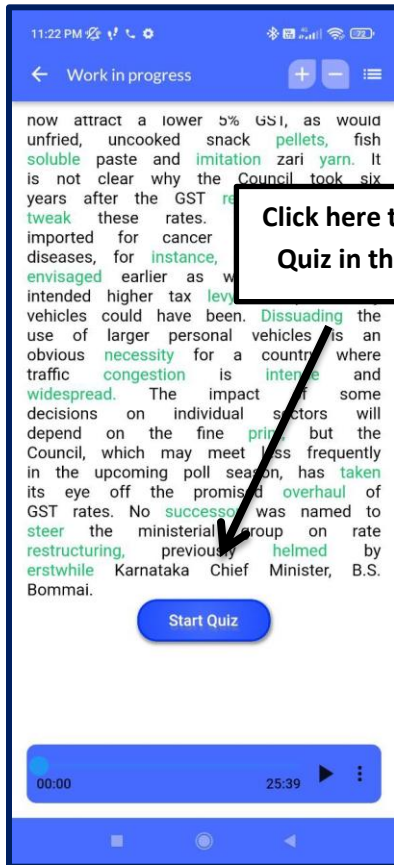
1. **Monetise** (verb) – Convert into money, generate revenue from, commercialize, profit from, make money from मुद्रीकरण करना
2. **Commercialisation** (noun) – Making commercial, turning into a business, marketization, commodification व्यावसायीकरण
3. **Undermine** (verb) – Weaken, sabotage, diminish, erode, destabilize कमजोर करना
4. **Inclusive** (adjective) – Comprehensive, all-encompassing, embracing, universal, open to all समावेशी
5. **Affordable** (adjective) – Inexpensive, reasonably priced, economical, budget-friendly, within reach सस्ती
6. **Remark** (verb) – Comment, observe, state, note, mention टिप्पणी करना
7. **Financial crunch** (noun) – Financial difficulty, economic crisis, monetary shortage, fiscal squeeze, money problems आर्थिक संकट
8. **Repurpose** (verb) – Adapt, reuse, reassign, modify, reallocate पुनः उद्देश्य देना
9. **Rhyme** (verb) – Align, resonate, correspond, echo, match मेल खाना
10. **Societal** (adjective) – Social, communal, public, relating to society सामाजिक
11. **Perception** (noun) – View, understanding, interpretation, insight, awareness धारणा
12. **Evaluate** (verb) – Assess, judge, appraise, estimate, measure मूल्यांकन करना
13. **Central** (adjective) – Main, primary, crucial, key, fundamental केंद्रीय
14. **Solely** (adverb) – Only, exclusively, entirely, purely, singularly केवल
15. **Profound** (adjective) – Deep, significant, meaningful, intense, thoughtful गहरा
16. **Mould** (verb) – Shape, form, influence, create, sculpt ढालना
17. **Reflective** (adjective) – Thoughtful, contemplative, introspective, meditative, pensive चिंतनशील
18. **Assess** (verb) – Evaluate, judge, measure, estimate, appraise आकलन करना
19. **Enlightened** (adjective) – Informed, educated, aware, knowledgeable, wise प्रबुद्ध
20. **Decade** (noun) – Period of ten years दशक
21. **Transition** (noun) – Change, shift, transformation, conversion, passage परिवर्तन
22. **Prompt** (verb) – Cause, trigger, provoke, incite, stimulate प्रेरित करना
23. **Ideology** (noun) – Beliefs, principles, doctrine, philosophy, worldview विचारधारा

24. **Numerous** (adjective) – Many, several, countless, multiple, abundant कई
25. **Resort** (to) (verb) – Turn to, use, rely on, fall back on, employ सहारा लेना
26. **Alliance** (noun) – Partnership, collaboration, association, coalition, union गठबंधन
27. **Impart** (verb) – Convey, give, communicate, bestow, share प्रदान करना
28. **Tenfold** (adjective) – Ten times, multiplied by ten, increased tenfold, ten times as much दस गुना
29. **Mandate** (verb) – Require, command, order, authorize, direct आदेश देना
30. **Pose** (verb) – Present, create, cause, constitute, bring about उत्पन्न करना
31. **Potential** (adjective) – Possible, prospective, latent, likely, possible संभावित
32. **Alter** (verb) – Change, modify, adjust, transform, amend बदलना
33. **Core** (adjective) – Central, fundamental, essential, primary, basic मुख्य
34. **Detrimental** (to) (adjective) – Harmful, damaging, injurious, adverse, destructive हानिकारक
35. **Intellectual** (adjective) – Mental, cerebral, scholarly, academic, thoughtful बौद्धिक
36. **Perspective** (noun) – Viewpoint, outlook, approach, stance, perception दृष्टिकोण
37. **Perhaps** (adverb) – Maybe, possibly, conceivably, probably, it could be शायद
38. **Overlook** (verb) – Ignore, neglect, miss, disregard, fail to notice नजरअंदाज करना
39. **Vital** (adjective) – Crucial, essential, important, necessary, indispensable महत्वपूर्ण
40. **Critical thinking** (noun) – a kind of thinking in which you question, analyse, interpret, evaluate and make a judgement about what you read, hear, say, or write. आलोचनात्मक सोच
41. **Broad-based** (adjective) – Comprehensive, wide-ranging, inclusive, extensive, all-encompassing व्यापक
42. **Distinct** (adjective) – Different, unique, separate, individual, discrete विशिष्ट
43. **Social fabric** (noun) – Social Fabric is made when all these individual members interact with one another सामाजिक संरचना
44. **Bureaucrat** (noun) – Government official, civil servant, administrator, public servant, functionary नौकरशाह
45. **Groom** (verb) – Train, prepare, cultivate, develop, nurture तैयार करना
46. **At large** (phrase) – Generally, in general, as a whole, broadly, overall सामान्य रूप में

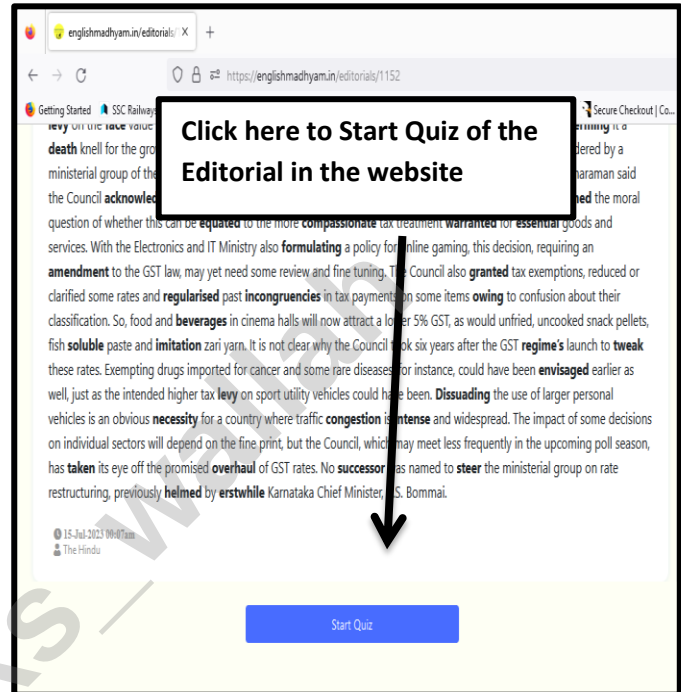
Summary of the Editorial

1. **Financial Challenges:** The Vice-Chancellor of JNU highlighted the financial difficulties faced by the university, pushing for monetisation of its assets.
2. **Policy Shift:** There is a growing trend among policymakers to view public academic institutions as potential revenue sources.
3. **Prime Land:** Public sector institutions often hold valuable land, making them targets for monetisation.
4. **Societal Perception:** Modern society increasingly values entities based on their financial output, influencing the push towards commercialisation.
5. **Educational Mission:** The core mission of public institutions is to provide inclusive, high-quality education, not to generate profit.
6. **Public Good:** Education should be treated as a public good, benefiting society as a whole, not as a commodity to be bought and sold.
7. **Enlightened Minds:** The true value of public education lies in producing knowledgeable, reflective citizens who contribute to societal progress.
8. **Business-Oriented Pressure:** Public institutions face pressure to adopt business strategies due to reduced government funding and rising operational costs.
9. **Alternative Revenue Sources:** Many public universities are seeking income through tuition hikes, online programs, and partnerships with private entities.
10. **Impact on Academia:** The focus on revenue generation risks compromising academic standards and intellectual diversity.
11. **Profit-Driven Priorities:** There is a danger that profit-oriented programs may overshadow less lucrative but equally important fields of study.
12. **Holistic Education:** It is essential to maintain a broad-based education that fosters critical thinking, rather than focusing solely on profitable disciplines.
13. **Social Fabric:** Public institutions play a crucial role in maintaining the nation's social fabric by nurturing critical thinkers and future leaders.
14. **Potential Harm:** Monetising every aspect of public education could undermine its foundational purpose and societal contribution.
15. **Preserving Core Values:** To continue producing great minds, public education must resist the pressure to monetise and maintain its focus on intellectual and social development.

Practice Exercise: Banking Pattern Based



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